

The gharial is multiplying faster at the Patna zoo than the authorities would care for. Taking care of the reptiles is posing its own problems now.

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

For a species classified as critically endangered, *Gavialis gangeticus*, or the gharial, has had it good over the years at Patna zoo. From just 11 in 2002, there are now over 130 gharials in the zoo, officially called the Sanjay Gandhi Biological Park. And the number is only set to grow. Wildlife enthusiasts would find in this a reason for cheer but officials see this as a problem of plenty. The solution they have come up with is to release them from captivity into the river Gandak of Bihar. But this has raised the hackles of conservationists who fear that gharials born and bred in captivity may not be able to survive in the wild.

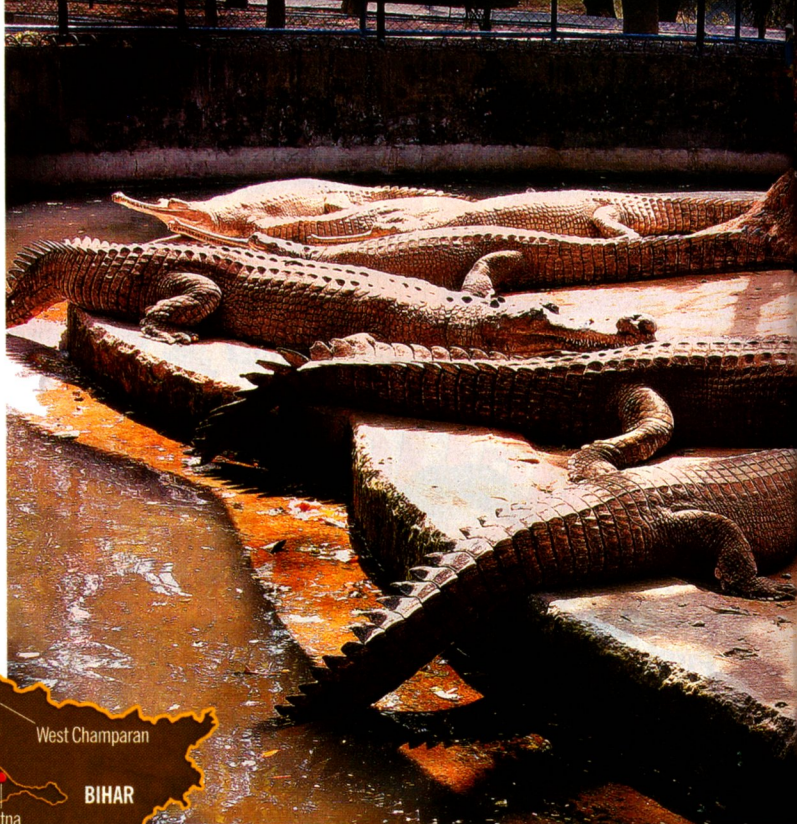
Rakesh Kumar, the director of the Patna zoo, explains that the institution has space for only 45 reptiles. Today, the two existing enclosures house 130 in total. The first enclosure has 11 big adults, including two 14 ft-long males. Male gharials can often reach 18 to 20 feet and are identified by the bulbous growth on the tip of their snouts. The second enclosure has over a 100 young gharials. "The younger ones are transferred to the second enclosure within a month of their birth to save them from being crushed between the bigger ones," says Kumar.

The situation may only worsen with the winter hibernation of the reptiles coming to an end. Breeding will begin after that as the cooling period stimulates the production of sperms in males and ovulation in females. The only way to tackle the rising numbers, according to the state Forest and Environment minister Ramchandra Sahni and Kumar is to transfer these additional gharials to river Gandak, considered their natural habitat in Bihar's West Champaran district.

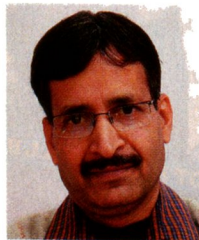
This, however, is not a wise solution

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according to wildlife experts. According to them, brought up in a cocooned shell in the zoo, these gharials are not capable of hunting for food. They are fed 80 to 130 kg of fish every week by the zoo authorities. "Survival would be a tall order for the gharials if they are suddenly forced to hunt and arrange food on their own," says a state forest department official. According to him, while such a transfer would end the immediate problem, it would only end up giving rise to a worse one.



Also, releasing the reptiles in Gandak, which is reported to have significantly high levels of pollution, can only have dangerous consequences. Ninetyfive reptiles in river Chambal have died in the last few months because of polluted water. The banks of Gandak do not even have enough sand to provide natural nesting ground for gharials. Plenty of fishermen also operate in these rivers and their fishing nets may become underwater webs of death for the reptiles. Releasing the animals in the wild

"We cannot show just gharials to visitors of the zoo."

RAKESH KUMAR, DIRECTOR, SANJAY GANDHI BIOLOGICAL PARK, PATNA